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# Reflections from Beyond the Bend for Sunday August 17, 2025

1 message

**Laura Harvey | Beyond the Bend Yoga** <laura@beyondthebendyoga.ca> Sun, Aug 17, 2025 at 1:48 PM
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## *Hi Laura*

I've been re-exploring a book called *Eastern Body, Western Mind*. It takes the ancient chakra system - a map of seven energy centers in the body - and pairs it with modern psychology to show how our life experiences shape us from the inside out.

Each chakra reflects a layer of who we are - from our sense of safety and belonging to our voice, vision, and purpose. And just like any map, it's not here to judge where I am. It's here to help me find my way.

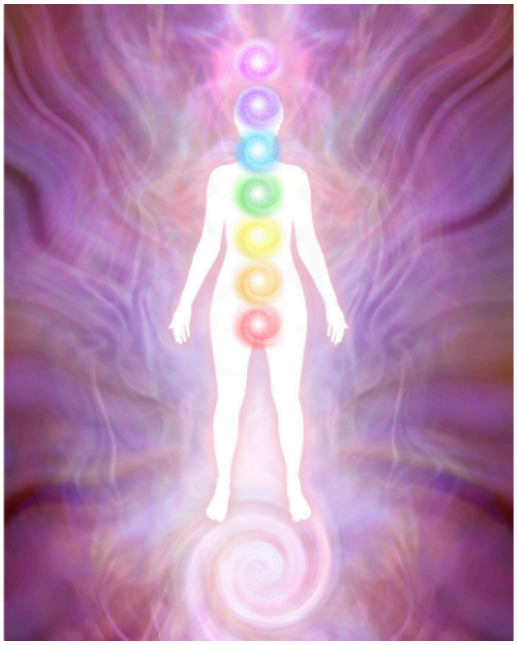
**Why This Matters for Us in Midlife:**

Midlife can stir questions about identity, direction, and wholeness. Sometimes, what's calling for our attention isn't a new "fix" - it's tending to a place in ourselves that's been waiting for care for years.

*Eastern Body, Western Mind* reminds me that personal growth isn't about climbing to the "top" of the chakra system. It's about weaving balance between them - honoring the root as much as the crown.

With warmth and gratitude,
Laura

## This Week's Wellness Wisdom



# 7 Gateways to Balance

### By Laura Harvey | Beyond the Bend Yoga

In yoga and mindfulness, we often focus on the here and now - the breath in your body, the stretch in your spine, the quiet between thoughts. But sometimes it's helpful to step back and see the bigger picture of how all the parts of you - physical, emotional, and spiritual - connect.

The chakra system is one such map. In *Eastern Body, Western Mind*, Anodea Judith blends this ancient Eastern model with Western psychology, showing how our life stories shape each "energy center" in the body. It's not about perfection - it's about awareness and balance.

# The Seven Chakras: A Gentle Guide

### 1. **Root Chakra** (*Muladhara*) - "I am"

**Location:** Base of spine
**Theme:** Safety, stability, survival
**When balanced:** You feel grounded, secure, supported.
**When imbalanced:** Anxiety, instability, fear around money or home.
**Practice:** Grounding yoga poses, time in nature, mindful walking.

### 2. **Sacral Chakra** (*Svadhisthana*) - "I feel"

**Location:** Lower abdomen
**Theme:** Pleasure, creativity, emotional flow
**When balanced:** Joy in simple pleasures, healthy relationships, creativity flows.

**When imbalanced:** Emotional numbness, guilt, overindulgence.
**Practice:** Creative play, gentle hip-opening poses, mindful movement.

### 3. **Solar Plexus Chakra** (*Manipura*) – "I do"

**Location:** Upper abdomen
**Theme:** Personal power, will, confidence
**When balanced:** Healthy self-esteem, clear boundaries, purposeful action.
**When imbalanced:** Self-doubt, control issues, passivity or aggression.
**Practice:** Core-strengthening poses, affirmations of self-worth, breath of fire.

### 4. **Heart Chakra** (*Anahata*) – "I love"

**Location:** Center of chest
**Theme:** Love, compassion, connection
**When balanced:** Openness to give and receive love, forgiveness, empathy.
**When imbalanced:** Isolation, bitterness, over-giving.
**Practice:** Heart-opening poses, gratitude journaling, loving-kindness meditation.

### 5. **Throat Chakra** (*Vishuddha*) – "I speak"

**Location:** Throat
**Theme:** Truth, self-expression, communication
**When balanced:** Honest expression, good listening, clarity in speech.
**When imbalanced:** Fear of speaking up, over-talking, miscommunication.
**Practice:** Chanting, singing, journaling, practicing honest but kind conversations.

### 6. **Third Eye Chakra** (*Ajna*) – "I see"

**Location:** Between the eyebrows
**Theme:** Intuition, insight, imagination
**When balanced:** Clear vision for life, trust in intuition, wisdom.
**When imbalanced:** Confusion, overthinking, disconnected from inner guidance.
**Practice:** Meditation, visualization, time in quiet reflection.

### 7. **Crown Chakra** (*Sahasrara*) – "I know"

**Location:** Top of head
**Theme:** Spiritual connection, higher purpose
**When balanced:** Sense of unity, peace, meaning.
**When imbalanced:** Disconnection, cynicism, spiritual bypassing.
**Practice:** Silent meditation, prayer, moments of awe in nature.

Perhaps this week you might choose one chakra that resonates most with you.
Ask yourself:
*What's one gentle action I can take to bring more balance here?*
Then, notice what shifts.

# September Classes Are Just Around the Corner

Three wonderful classes to choose from.
Whether you want to ground, flow, or pause,
you can choose one, two, or all three.

## 🌿 Somatic Vinyasa

**Mondays, 6:00 – 7:15 PM**
**September 15 – October 27**
📍 *Rising Moon Studio, Sherwood Park* - a beautiful, intimate setting with a cozy fireplace for the cooler evenings.

*This class isn't about doing more. It's about noticing more.*
No pressure. No pretzels. Just movement that feels good in a real body on a real day.
We move slow. We breathe deep. We actually pay attention to how things feel.
This class blends breath-led movement with somatic awareness, so you can build strength without bulldozing your nervous system. Expect mindful flow, grounded movement, and maybe a few deep sighs of relief.

## 🌿 Restore & Reclaim

**Restorative Yoga for Nervous System Recovery & Deep Rest**
**Tuesdays | 6:00 – 7:15 PM**
**September 16 – October 28** (7-week session)
📍 *Rising Moon Studio, Sherwood Park*

This 75-minute class is designed to help you unwind, soften tension, and return to yourself. Gentle movement, breathwork, and long-held supported poses offer a powerful reset for your nervous system.

## 🌿 The Pause Practice (Menopause Circle)

**Wednesdays, 10:00 – 11:15 AM**
**September 17 – October 30**
📍 *Rising Moon Studio, Sherwood Par*

A slow, grounding class designed for women navigating the shifts of peri/menopause and beyond. Gentle movement, breathwork, and connection with zero pressure to perform. Come as you are. Exhale.

**Investment:**
🌿 **$17/class when registering for the full session (7 weeks = $119)**
🌿 **$20 drop-in (if space allows)**

*Spaces are limited. Priority goes to full session registrations.*

***Fall Classes Now Open for Registration***

# Your Practice This Week

## Chakra Check-In

**Purpose:**
To connect with each of your seven energy centers, notice where there's flow or tension, and invite gentle balance.

## Step 1 – Find Your Seat

Sit comfortably with your feet on the ground. Close your eyes or soften your gaze. Take three slow, deep breaths.

## Step 2 – Gentle Awareness Through the Chakras

Bring your attention to each area of the body, moving from base to crown. At each chakra, pause to notice sensations, emotions, or imagery that arise.

1. **Root (Base of Spine)** – *I am grounded.*
   Notice your connection to the floor. Imagine a warm, steady red light here.
   Ask: *Do I feel supported and safe right now?*

2. **Sacral (Lower Abdomen)** – *I feel.*
   Sense into your hips and lower belly. Visualize an orange glow.
   Ask: *Am I allowing joy, creativity, and emotional flow?*

3. **Solar Plexus (Upper Abdomen)** – *I do.*
   Feel the area around your stomach and ribs. Imagine a golden yellow warmth.
   Ask: *Where do I feel confident and capable? Where do I hold tension?*

4. **Heart (Center of Chest)** – *I love.*
   Notice your breath moving through the chest. Picture a soft green light.
   Ask: *What wants to be forgiven or embraced?*

5. **Throat (Center of Throat)** – *I speak.*
   Sense the throat and jaw. Imagine a sky-blue light.
   Ask: *Am I speaking my truth with kindness?*

6. **Third Eye (Between Brows)** – *I see.*
   Gently focus between your eyebrows. Visualize deep indigo.
   Ask: *What is my inner wisdom showing me right now?*

7. **Crown (Top of Head)** – *I know.*
   Sense the space above your head. Picture a soft violet or white light.
   Ask: *Where do I feel connected to something greater?*

## Step 3 – Close the Practice

Take a slow breath in through the nose, and exhale through the mouth.
Open your eyes and notice how you feel now compared to when you began.

**Optional Journal Prompt:**
*Which chakra felt the most open? Which felt the most in need of attention? What's one small step I can take this week to nurture that space?*

## 🍃 Private 1:1 Restorative Yoga - Online

Personalized nervous system support for deep rest + reconnection.

These one-on-one sessions are a soft landing place when you're moving through burnout, grief, anxiety, or simply craving quiet space. You'll be gently guided through restorative postures, breathwork, and stillness practices — tailored completely to your needs.

✨ **60 min via Zoom**
✨ **$90/session | $340/4 | $640/8**
✨ **Free 15-min discovery call available**

**LEARN MORE AND SIGN-UP**

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